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Wilson "Chembo" Corniel

Wilson "Chembo" Corniel is a master of the tumbadoras. He is a native of New York City and a much-respected musician in the world of Afro-Cuban jazz. He performs with the Bronx Conexion Latin Jazz Big Band, and has released his own solo recordings on Chemboro Records.

Chembo was interviewed in Clinton, New York on November 15, 2019 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we're in the Fillius Jazz Archive. I'm very pleased to have Wilson "Chembo" Corniel with me today. And my head is still sort of spinning from that wonderful demonstration/performance that the three of you gave yesterday. And I think I mentioned to Victor that most musicians that play club dates and that kind of thing, when they get asked to play a Latin tune, everyone plays "The Girl From Ipanema." We know that. We can play a bossa nova. And then we're sort of stunned to learn how much more there is out there.

WC: Oh yeah.

MR: Did you grow up with this just as part of the fabric of your childhood?

WC: It is part of it, but the thing is when I was born and raised in New York City so I had all these other influences around me, you know, like I grew up with the Beatles, Motown, Glen Campbell, Willie Nelson, the Temptations, Rolling Stones. You know so it's a whole mixture of different things besides my Latin roots that I picked up at home, the records that my mother played, the Tito Rodriguez, Machito, all the ballad singers, you know, so that's always been in my ear, the Latin part, besides my surroundings growing up you know, as a whole, as a musician as a whole. But as I grew up and played my conga drums I played with — I started off playing with salsa bands, salsa, you know, Latin music. And that's my foundation, salsa music. So by listening to records and listening and knowing what the combination is with the percussion — you know we have to be percussionists. We have a timbale player, you know, bongo player, for a traditional salsa set up. So you have to know the functions of each drum to work as unison, as one. It's not just banging away. There's a chemistry, there's a technique in order for it to mesh. And that technique, you've got to learn, you've got to know the basic patterns of that in order for you to grow and for you to do any other Latin style, that is the key to hold up. If you want to do a Latin tune for your club date band, if you know those components, and then you can start up and do a little basic that's not going to be watered down but it's going to be authentic. You know we, myself and people that I work with

with the Latin people there, we go out of our way to learn jazz traditionally. You know we go and spend the time so when we've got to set up and do a jazz gig it's going to sound like a jazz gig. It's not going to sound like a watered down fake chords, you're gonna know the theory behind what you're doing and stuff, so you can go out and play authentically. You're not going to wash it down. You know each style of music — if I'm going to study flamenco music it's going to be the traditional style. If I'm going to do some straight ahead jazz, if I'm going to do some pop music, you know there's certain elements — I won't play the same with each genre. There's a key — I call it the law — the law is there's certain laws — I can't do this here, I don't need a full Latin set up when I do a pop gig. So this is why I have my drums and my effects, my toys, because this is more colors. I do a Latin gig and I know I'm expecting conga, bongo, timbales. If I'm going to do a jazz gig, you know, it's a different approach of playing that, even as a percussionist. So I'm not playing the same thing, banging away to everything. There's a certain elements. See I play with Grady Tate and he's a singer, and lightly. I don't even have to put my hand on the conga, the full hand on it. I just do my fingertips just to get a little sound, enough to back him up without overpowering him. And Latin music, you've got to blow. So you've got to know those things first. So when I sit down here and the guy says, "Man you sound great" but I haven't done anything. All I did was follow the path that I was supposed to. And then on top of that you put your own soul into it.

MR: In other words you fit in first.

WC: Right. First. And then you've got to experiment. Like you go through the doors, see what's happening in there, you know you can walk through further, say hi, so you're kind of introducing yourself to each song and each style. So this is why we have — we also, you know we go out into studying this full, to the full extent of each genre. Latin people. So and it dawns on me why not, when the American people play a Latin tune, they won't go out and study these laws — the basics — a little tumbao on the piano, a little montuno. How to play, we told — the same situation. I'm doing a lot of club dates so the guy wanted to play a little mambo, dance music you know, salsa, right? The piano player goes [scats]. I said, "What is that?" "That's Brazil, that's a samba." [scats] It's not 1-4-5 montuno as a Latin thing. So that's all they have in their mind because they don't take the time out to study Noro Morales, Tito Puente, Machito, you know the basic things. You know we had Ray Santos who just passed away teaching at City College and teaching these young students the way to do a certain — and it's easy but they don't take the time out into studying our music in order for that to sound correct at a club date.

MR: So is studying the music mostly an oral thing listening to recordings?

WC: It's both listening, but you have to play. You have to attack it. Because you can listen to it now, transmitted to your hands so you can play it the way you hear it. You know? So

now you have to do a lot of listening because there's a lot of different styles. Latin music, it's not just Latin music. There's big band Latin music, there's cojunto there's charanga there's son montuno there's trio music. So which branch of Latin music that you play now. So now we start to open up the can. What do you want to do? Do you like big band? So I'm going to listen to Machito, I'm going to listen to not even Xavier Cugat, he was kind of a cross bridge between the Latin and the American you know. He was kind of commercial.

MR: Right. You'd find his, like my parents would have had his LPs.

WC: Right. That's an LP, right? Xavier Cugat. I got the chance to perform with him too, with the group, but he wasn't there, but the piano player was the leader. Me and Victor. Victor got me the gig. We did a gig with his band. But you see so now we're starting to divide this thing up. Now for instance, big band for a percussionist, I'm a conga player, I'm expecting a bongo player, you're going to see tonight, and a timbale player. That's the full rhythm section of a big band. When you play cojunto, cojunto is only like maybe three trumpets, not like a big band, four four and four, or five, four and four, whatever. Cohunto is only four or three trumpets, it's only a conga and bongo. Charanga it's another style of music, three violins and a flute and that's a conga and a timbale only. So those combinations you've got to know first of all. I'm not going to bring a pair of bongos to a charanga gig because there is no bongo. So see those are the things that we have to, you know, teach first in order to start — you know it's not as black and white as it is. This is not what style you're playing and who are you listening to. Who plays that style? What groups? Charanga Aragon — Aragon is like Cuba's, like top charanga band, it's been over 65 years you know. And this is the typical — charanga is the style of music of a cross between classical and it was like an upper class music because they had violins and flute but they put it into a cha cha cha and to a son montuno but you still had the violins. It's more of a high society music, at the time. And they had danzones which is a French contra-dance, with classical music, but it went into a classical piece for the intro, then it goes into a son montuno a chacha, the body. And then the head out is the same as the head in, it finishes out in the classical setting.

MR: Oh sort of like a jazz tune, you've got the head at the beginning and at the end.

WC: Right. So you go back, but in the middle they did a dance part for the people, and that's where the Latin part came in. But you would start off at a sweet, and then a certain break [scats] and that's when everybody starts going crazy and dancing but, and after that you would finish [scats] you know, to end it off. So if you're going to study charanga, flute players, sax and flute players listen to a lot of — flute players will listen to a charanga music because that's a whole style in itself. Socarras, a flute player, a Cuban flute player that toured a lot, Alberto Socarras, he is one of the guys that taught in New York and he

is like one of the guys from Cuba, old school guys that had that style, that grew up in that style. Jose Fajardo, flute. They played the black, Cuban flute, the wooden flute, five holes, open holed, open holed.

MR: Unbelievable.

WC: Not the metal one with the pads. So, and you know you've got a big band, Tito Puente, five saxes, four trombones, four trumpets, timbale, bongo, two singers you know, so it's a full force. And that's a different way of playing that, see? So this is what has to be first of all, taught for us, so you're not watering down — if you know certain things a little, at least 101, in a montuno, know a couple of timbao, like we did yesterday at the class, the second thing. We did that C7 montuno with Victor. See, that's a basic. If you could play that at any of those club dates, that's passable and so easy you know. And the thing is taking a time out and really get involved with that.

MR: What do you do if you get called to play like a piano trio gig plus percussion and it's going to be mostly swing music? I mean is that harder to fit into?

WC: No because luckily, like I say, born and raised in New York I played with different — I played with a duo, I played with a trio, sax, bass and congas.

MR: Cool.

WC: And it works. We did a favorite group, Paul Carlon, a tenor player, he couldn't make it today. Paul Carlon.

MR: I know Paul Carlon.

WC: You know Paul?

MR: His mother lives up here.

WC: Right. He's from up here.

MR: Yes he played here for an educational —

WC: I recorded his trio record you see? So you listen to Paul Carlon, it's called "Tresillo." And I'm on that and it's just acoustic bass, tenor, and me on two congas only. And you're going to see how that works. Ask him about the new record. Tell him. So with that training, jazz things — because we go in and out, of different genres, different things, different colors, we can take it out and yet we have the tumbao in there you know, the main machine is running in there. So when I'm doing jazz I bring one conga and I bring some shakers, some colors. It's not going to be all congas because I'm going to straight ahead. But there's a style of playing conga in a jazz tumbao [scats] so it could fit in, you don't even need a drummer because I could fit that part in there. You see? But this is the way that my training, growing up in New York City where all these different environs you know.

MR: I was imagining yesterday listening to the three of you what would cause you to look — give somebody a look like what are you doing. I mean you all knew each other.

Obviously. But sometimes you get thrown together with different people just like okay I've got a gig let me get a band. But what would — because this is a conversation right? So what would someone do to make you like wince and —

WC: Well throughout my lifetime it happened a lot of times. It happened a lot of times. You know different people will take it differently you know. Some people would yell or the guy like, what are you doing, or you're not listening, or they would say something about it. Other people would adapt to it and shut up. Okay, this is what this guy's got to offer so let me work around it so I can bridge it and fill in the gaps, so I've got to carry him here because he's not listening to me, so then my approach is different. And I can't overplay. Now I've got to hold time because this guy's going crazy. So then I've got to hold time because you know, I've got to have time and space to open up. If he's taking up all the space here, so what am I going to do. If I'm going to do it at the same time we're going to be like this [gestures]. It's like two people talking at the same time. So if he's not giving me the time to respond to you, I'll just keep quiet and then when he gets tired I'll sneak in there. So there's ways I work around that and then I know for next time, who's on the gig? This guy's on it so I got something else. You know? Because he has no concept. He needs to study. He's got no concept. It's a conversation you see, you heard it yesterday with the three. Each one had their spot. We didn't have to fight for it. You know? Whenever it's there it's there. It's a conversation.

MR: There was a great moment when I think you'd been talking about how someone asked a question about how much improvisation is involved in most of the things. And the answer was that not as much as you might think. And then you played one of the rhythms and Victor at one point gave this big smile. He looked at you guys, and obviously you had just done something a little out of the ordinary, which I'm assuming was improvised. So what is my question. I'm not sure I have a question, except it was very noticeable.

WC: Okay well the answer is that you know he might have done something, he said a conversation was just playing then loudly I answered him back, I communicated back with him like it was a give and take kind of thing and this is what it's about you know. If I was improvising because I was doing the solo parts on the quinto on the congas and he was playing his parts there, and when everybody is — first of all the ensemble has to be there first of all, together. Because we have to play where we're not fighting each other, we're laying a bed first so you can lay on top and relax and do what you want to do, but the conversation and the ensemble part has to be together first before you go to the next step as far as your improvisation. Okay? So when he probably heard some communication between us or between us three somewhere, that it was in time because this is what we play for and this is through experience you get it. You know? Because you can't say okay let's talk first and you do this first. You can't plan that. This is what

improvisation is. You can't plan it. I'm hearing you say [garbled speech] so it's got — or I might do a riff and then you might do the same rhythmically, like on your solo, you could be blowing and I can do a little [scats] you know then you can answer me back to give you something to grab onto, to communicate back with me. Like I hear you. So I think this is one of those moments that we strive to look for, when it's not planned.

MR: But not overdoing it like that fellow you mentioned that you don't want to play with again.

WC: Right. Right. See that, you've got to know the concept, see he doesn't know concept then. I know he'd deny it. He's not a guy who's listening or studying this music for him to be playing like that. You know? You play by yourself then if you want to be taking all the spots. Give somebody else a chance to talk. It's a conversation you have — somebody always talking and talking you say I'm going home why am I going to stay over here. You know?

MR: It happens on every level. Like if you go to a blues jam session there'll be people up there who are so anxious to show what they can do that they don't play within the concept of the music.

WC: Right. Well you know that's the feeling that we need to carry over within all genres. And that happens, and once you have that with that, with whatever style of music you play, that carries onto everything else because you don't want to lay out. You know? It's not all playing all the time, but you've got to hear the whole piece and see where you're going to fit in. You're not just going to jump in there and say [garbled speech] without knowing what we're talking about. You know? So if you had that concept why couldn't this other guy have that concept too. If he's a musician then he's not studying. I mean you know he needs to study more about the what do you call it, the — like the theory, not the theory but this is now with the performing and the experience of performing.

MR: The etiquette.

WC: Right. Of playing, especially you've got this in jazz because it's so free that you can go anywhere but you've got to contain it. It's not like a boxer, he's not going to give it all of his fighting the first round, he's not going to give all his thing and tire himself out. He's waiting and feeling you out, okay here it is, he ain't going to last ten rounds. You know? Imagine you're swinging the first round, you'll fall on the floor. You know? You've got to feel it out, it's the same thing. You've got your space, you've got your time, and it's going to come and you feel it.

MR: Someone wrote a review about you and your recordings and it says, "As clave conscious as he may be he has never been content with just being a timekeeper, nor does he look to hog the solo spotlight all for himself." So it sounds like just what you're talking about.

WC: Yes. Because that happens with my quintet, a lot of people come to me and say, "You let these guys shine." I lay out sometimes because I have a Latin jazz quintet but I consider my group jazz-Latin. It's a jazz band with congas. That's how I approach. Because once you hear "Latin music," they think you've got a singer, it's a salsa band, so Latin jazz is a whole genre in itself. One guy on a radio station asked me, "Do you think Latin jazz is a legitimate genre?" I said, "What." I said okay. Well who's the founder of that? Who is the guy that made it popular. It's Dizzy and Chano. In 1945 when Chano Pozo came from Cuba, Mario Bauza introduced him to Dizzy Gillespie. This is where "Manteca," "Tin Tin Deo" all those numbers — so if you don't think Dizzy Gillespie is legitimate enough — he's the one who is the father of Latin jazz but before him it was Machito and Mario Bauza. Dizzy only made it popular, that hey this music is happening. It's been happening big band style since the 40s already. So when Chano came in he just mixed in with Diz and that's the marriage with jazz and Latin see? So therefore then I say you think Dizzy is not legitimate? You say well he's the best. Well he's the father of this. You know? So this is why I put him in the spot there you know. That's what it is.

MR: So what's it like to make a living as a musician in New York City. Do you have to wear lots of hats?

WC: Oh yeah, especially for myself, I'm an independent record company, Chemboro Records, I've had it since 2004. I have five CDs under my label. The third CD, "Things I Wanted to Do" in 2010 was nominated for a Grammy of Best Latin Jazz by the American Grammy, NARAS. I was nominated along with Chucho Valdes, Miguel Zenon, Claudio Roditi, and Geoff Keezer, pianist I guess. But when you have a name like Chucho Valdes, "Who is Chembo?" "Who is Chembo?" But at least being nominated and being an independent, so I have to wear the hat of being a promoter, I'm my accountant, I'm the band boy, I'm the manager, I'm the booking agent. Then I've got to practice. So of course I'm wearing all these hats because I'm independent. I'm not going to go to a manager who has five bands, and he's going to give the work to his top guys, he'll give you the crumbs. You know I just pick up the phone and I'll do all that myself. It's harder you know, it's harder because I have to do all that. It's not like before. Clubs are closing you know, so I have to look for these circuits with the colleges. And I like that I see there was a void in learning our music this way, like I was explaining to you. You know I feel that we — doing these rounds, I just came last week I was at Tufts doing the same thing. I did two clinics and I did a concert with the professor's Latin jazz band at the school. And I was there with my group last year doing the same thing. So he puts me into his jazz class with his students and we do the same thing, and try to show them a little one-on-one mambo, tumbao, Latin, you know, to be the real style and how to play a clave. The clave is so important because in Latin music, the clave in Spanish music is key. That's the key

to the music. They say, "La clave es la llave." The clave is the key. Okay? So the reason why is that when you play clave, which is say a three-two, I'm going to tap it like [claps] right? Everybody knows that. This is a two bar phrase. One-two-three-four, one-two-three-four, one-two-three-four, two-two-three four. Right on two-three-four, two. So this is a two bar phrase. In that music we write in two bar phrases so you won't jump. In jazz you do one bar, one bar here and there, and that's why you know you might do a two-bar phrase generally but if you put in an extra bar here and there it flips it around. So this is why it's so important like when you're writing a Latin tune, that is the basis first of all, that it's even. You're writing every two bars.

MR: Why would you choose to do the two-three clave as opposed to —

WC: Well it depends on the phrasing, on the phrasing that you want to do. Like say you have a phrasing in your mind with the horn [scats] two-three, it's a pick-up. You know? So it depends on the phrasing and then that'll show you what side of the clave to put it, and then you start there and you continue. Now the reason why we phrase around that clave as a frame, because that's what the dancers dance to.

MR: But someone — it doesn't always have to be played. Is that correct?

WC: No. It's not being played but it's emphasized on each part of the instrument. It's accented on the three, you hear a certain downbeat, you hear a certain phrase [scats]. He's phrasing I allowed it, so he's telling me where the clave is. There's a bass pattern [scats] — so now I know where it is on the bass so by his phrasing. So this is after years of, you have to have it engrained you know, but first you've got to figure it out and follow it. When I play a tunbao on the congas I'm playing, I'm hitting a certain part of the clave too so my rhythm is also telling everyone where the clave is too, in the way I phrase it: two-three-three-two, the accent's where I'm going to hit the and of four or on the fourth beat [scats]. So when you hear that downbeat on the four you know it's three sides, the fourth meet on the third side, see? So it's all in the instruments. So once you get used to it, and then when everybody's phrasing on it, you can't lose it. You know? You hear it.

MR: I can lose it.

WC: Yeah I know, but I'm talking about for us who know this is how we get into that. So but the timbale player will hit a rhythm on the side, like he was showing the drummer. [taps] So if the drummer is on a cymbal [scats]. So he's playing that phrase, so he's playing with the clave too. So you go [scats] you see? So therefore this is what we try to do and what we did yesterday with me, Cascadu and Victor with the percussion, all those rhythms from all around the world that we try to — it's so much more than what we did. But we got to learn it from the folkloric from the really root of each rhythm, from where they come from.

MR: What was that word you used?

WC: Folkloric. Yes. You know so we try to take each rhythm from the ground and dissect it from there to bring it and mix it with the jazz. So we've got the jazz and we've got the roots, so my group is like that. We're doing the straight ahead jazz with the bottom from Africa. So you know I give opportunities to my musicians all the time where I give them space, I lay out sometimes, and this is why with that comment you said before, I don't hog up all the solos. You know it's my band but I'm not going to be blowing all the time, but I've got these great musicians here and I utilize it.

MR: You know people forget I think that silence is a sound.

WC: Ooh. Big one right there.

MR: Right?

WC: That's right. That's right.

MR: And when you come back in it's much more effective than if you hadn't laid out.

WC: Right. You've got to breathe when you speak. You have to take a breath and that's, silence is music also, but just like improvising around a clave, it's like also soloing is another technique of soloing any instrument with the clave. So you're flowing with [scats and claps] and then you've got to breathe. So there's phrasing in or out, you could do a phrase, take a breath. Because that breath is where I'm going to probably have a conversation with you. [scats] Or some kind of answer, call and answer might happen there, to help you inspire for your next — you know so this is how, you know we play with each other there but very few have that — you know if you get a group of guys here that has that mentality your band is going to swing without even starting, just by playing the music. Because we're playing it at a way that, don't worry, later on we're going to take it out. But at the end we come back to take it out. So when jazz, the improvisation, gives us the freedom, but you've got to know how to anchor it and this is where the other side comes in too. It's not the freedom for you to do anything but the other side of you holding the bottom, holding the rhythm and holding the time, and locking in and playing the clave and dynamics you know, playing soft in certain parts, bringing it up, bringing it down, you know, so it's all those colors together is what makes a complete band, musician also with that theory.

MR: Jazz for decades was mostly learned by finding a mentor and listening, aurally, and now it's a big business in education, and thousands of books and manuals on how to improvise and all that. Has the same thing happened with Latin music as far as now you can, all this stuff you're talking about is now written down?

WC: Oh yes. Oh yes definitely. You know because when I was a kid trying to find information we didn't have YouTube, we didn't have the internet. I had my album, I'd put on a record and I would hear the conga player but you would hear the dominant hand and you didn't know what the left hand was doing so therefore you were doing it wrong because you had

to see that there's a certain technique that fills in the whole pattern of a tumbao. All you hear is [scats] see that's the right hand only. But what's this one doing? There's another, there's the other half that you're learning. So you start picking up bad habits already until somebody who knows, and I got in contact with these people that moved in my neighborhood, professional percussionists that were playing with Eddie Palmieri in the 70s, and they seen that I had a little bit of talent so they took me up and cleaned me up and polished — then I was on my way even further. Then I learned how to read music on top of that. And then after that — which conga players, they never gave a chart to. They only give it to the brass players. I had to come with a cassette player and record the rehearsal and then memorize eight songs, all the breaks and all that stuff. This is how we did it. We didn't have the internet and they didn't teach you how to read. We didn't have Latin music in the schools. We didn't even have a conga in the school, we just had maracas and a guiro, which they called a fish. You know, the colored ones? You know? That was that guiro. You have the guiro for the cha cha cha. You know? We got a fish and some maracas. That was the extent of Latin music in my school. The rest I learned in the street. You know. We all had a conga, we go to the park and start playing, and then from there I got my sound, we got rhythms but we didn't know what we were doing but we were just banging and got a little groove always happening, the same groove but we kept for hours and hours and hours and days and days and days so I bumped into a lot of people here. I started — I was old enough to go to the clubs and seeing the professional bands and I would just stay there the whole night just in the corner looking at the conga player and seeing his hands and what he's doing, then I would practice it the next day you know, I would try to memorize some riffs you know. Then they started to open up a school, Boys Harbor School of Music in Harlem and then I went there where they're all Latinos, they had a piano, bass, vocals, percussion, and then that's where we started learning, those guys were helping us kids to read now and play the right rhythms and how to lock in and the concept of playing with the clave and playing together. So after a couple of years of that then I landed a gig with one of the top bands, when I was young, in 1977 Bobby Rodriguez Y La Compania we were like a band of kids, we were only 21 anyway. And we had a sound of Latin mix, because the leader was a sax player and he played clarinet. So we had a Dixieland salsa kind of a sound. So we would do some Dixieland stuff, because he had a clarinet, no other horns. Salsa band had the clarinet. So the brass was a trumpet, tenor, trombone. So you've got a lot of colors with those three. So the tenor player was the leader and he played flute, soprano and clarinet. So we go into a bebop swing [scats] and he would blow, like New Orleans style, you know. So we would mix that with Latin, it was something new and fresh and the people were dancing to it. You know so that band really put me on the map and started my career you know.

MR: Were your parents supportive of your musical path?

WC: Yes, yes. My mother was, my mother was. Because she tolerated me with my drum in the room all kind of hours trying to figure out stuff and playing my record player in my room you know, kind of loud. But I didn't do it at an inappropriate time or anything like that you know. Mamas, when we were kids, you've got to know your limit you know. But I didn't get any kind of negativity, never got held back by not doing this or don't do that you know kind of stuff.

MR: You know you made a comment when you came in today and our professor who brought you over, and you said something like, "I want to be like you when I grow up." And I'm wondering if this music keeps you young.

WC: Oh yeah. You know we just had this conversation and, back at the room over there at the hotel this morning. Because we were talking about Lionel Hampton and how these guys, when they get to their instrument, you had to help him up on stage but when he gets to the instruments he feels no pain and he's playing. There was another guy that Cascadu mentioned. Then I mentioned Candido, 98 years old and he's still playing. He wears a brace for his arthritis in the back. He can't stand up. He leans on the drum. They put the congas and he leans against them and he plays. He's like a kid. Like there's a part of the brain that keeps that — music heals. Music is medicine. And you could see with people with disabilities once they play music or sing or play an instrument, you know, they're exceptional. It's something about music that keeps you young. So there's a lot of these guys, Clark Terry, you know, all these guys. You had to help them on stage but they sat down and they played like nothing, you know.

MR: And they learned to play within, like if they lost their high notes they learned to play without them.

WC: It doesn't matter. Right. They have nothing to prove because they did what they had to do. But the thing is for him to be there and just to put the horn and get a sound out and still have the same melodic — you know he's talking to you like he would speak to you. He's not going to scream at you now, he's not fifty years younger. You know I mean that's how I see it, like you know music, it'll never get old in you because it's part of you. It's part of your vocal.

MR: Is there any physicality — I mean I know there's physicality to what you do. Does it manifest itself, like do you get sore? Like I remember this anecdote, we have a piano teacher here who played with Don Alias and he used to say that Don would have to like shave his calluses.

WC: Yeah. Well it depends on your hands too. You know each one — my hand sweats a little bit so there's a little moisture, you know drier hands, you know so it depends some it all plays a factor. This winter weather here chaps up my hands, cracks my hands a lot. I'm

always moisturizing and stuff. But it is a lot of physicality in my job because as a conga player we're not like a trumpet player or a brass player that just goes [scats] and put it down, rest for a couple of bars and then blow. We're the ones who from beginning to the end we play. But with all the years of playing, I had to learn how to make my job easier so this is where technique comes in. This is how you conserve your energy so you could have stamina and I could play for three or hours, play my drums straight. But breathing. There's a technique of breathing I kind of developed and learned, when I play usually a conga they will see it as a primitive instrument and right away what you want to do, bang on it real hard, right? You're going to break your hands. So I play with the weight of my hand. That's loud enough. Just drop it on the drum. So and there you've got a ground zero where you can build up or go down. If you're going to start here, what are you going to do up here? You know? So you play, so I have students and I teach them that first of all. The tuning of the drums, so there's specific notes for each conga, you can hear melodies. You hear Candido play "Manteca" on the drums, all those melodies.

MR: I heard you do that on one of your tunes. I wrote it down.

WC: Yeah. I do "Oye Como Va."

MR: That was it.

WC: [scats] But you know you've got to treat the drum like a violin when you play. You've got to tune it first. You're not going to go grab a violin. You know they've got to have that same respect as an instrument also. So you've got to sit down, you've got to tune it first and make sure everything — you've got the notes that you want. So right there half of your job is done. If you hear any drum it's going to sound pretty because it's in tune you know.

MR: I meant to ask about that, with the three of you yesterday. And what's the double-headed —

WC: Batá.

MR: Yeah the batá. Is that supposed to be the lowest pitch of the three of you?

WC: Yeah, the larger one is the deeper pitch, the big side is called the enu, E-N-U enu. And the smaller is called the chacha of the drums. So enu of the iya, which is the mother, is the deepest sound. I was playing the itotele in the middle, it's got like a mid sound. So we have notes that we tune to all those also. E flat in an E flat. E flat for the low drum and in the octave for the middle drum and then a B flat for the high one.

MR: Interesting.

WC: So we got those through records and then you know we hear what drums sound authentically and we try to find the note and we tune to that. So this is research that we're doing you know, to sound like them, like the real deal you know. And then plus knowing the rhythms. So that's the lowest one, that makes the call and I answer with my middle

drum. The little one keeps time all the way and holds us together. So it's all conversations, it's the same thing. So with that in mind, with that concept, the conversation is with everything. That's from Africa. That's what I call the first A T & T, the first texting. [scats] You know you answer. But those are the first A T & T you know, and texting and messages, and that same concept with the congas, we have them tuned and each one has a specific rhythm to play that when you're playing these three rhythms it will blend into one solid one.

MR: Do you tune them differently if you're playing with pitched instruments?

WC: What we do, for myself, I play congas. My default for the two congas is G and C. Middle C for my lead drum, and the G, because they have no sharps and flats. You're not going to tune it to every chart. You know, so it has no sharps and flats. But that's the most — fifths. And if I had a third drum I would do a B flat.

MR: Up a fourth. I mean yeah.

WC: Right? [scats] And my fourth drum I would do an E. [scats]. That would be a C 7 chord.

MR: Okay.

WC: That's where I play my melodies [scats]. "Oye Como Va" you see?

MR: I do see. So if you did that specific song then the rest of the band is playing in C also on purpose?

WC: No, no, no, no, no. It's only for the conga player, for me just to have, I can't tune to every key of every song so, but this is following the law of my default on tuning the drums with the G and C, this is only obvious or compatible notes that I can play within the G and C. I put the B flat, C, C7, and that's going to have to go with everything for the night. I did one time tune to each different key on a recording, for a recording. I had time you know, what key is this in — give me the four notes and I would tune it to that just to hear. But it was a pain you know, and it was awkward, it was kind of awkward you know, because now it's not the key that I was used to, the tuning that I was used to in order to, you know it just felt strange you know. So I just keep it like that all the time. And this is what mostly everybody should do, or some other people — Candido tuned — I got this tuning from Patato Valdez and Candido tunes his up a step higher. He would do D-C-A. So he's a more brighter sound. You know I like the G and C and B flat because it's warmer, it's in the middle, it's centered you know, it's a warmer, fatter, bigger sound for me.

MR: Okay. Have there been tunes that have come along that you feel like pop hits — let me go back. Jazz musicians, when, like Kenny G came out, most of them were like sort of disgusted at what he was doing. I think it shouldn't have been called jazz in the first place. But at any rate, like a tune like the Macarena in '97, do those kinds of sort of novelty Latin hits bother you?

WC: I see this is business you know. And he's looking at it as the standpoint of that. Kenny G I think also, a couple of years ago recorded a Latin record, tried to do a Latin album so he could enter it into the Latin Grammys since it's Kenny G — he thought maybe he would have a leg up on it or something, I don't know because it's Kenny G goes Latin. Cyndi Lauper did one but hers came out really good. Singing in English, Cyndi Lauper with real arrangements in clave, real musicians that know the stuff, and hip arrangements. But she sang in English, that was a killer. But Kenny G you know I see what you mean by that, because they're trying to step in, and this is all for me, it's more of a business kind of tactic, because musically it wasn't going to go nowhere, because people who know music, and the general public, they hear Macarena, they'd rather hear the real one instead of a watered down one you know. So I guess he just tried to, it was an invention, or see where I can go with this, to open up another avenue where I can make money. Maybe I could hit the Latin market now, then I'll do, whatever, you know, I'll do "La Bamba" next or something. You know? Maybe I can get over that way. But tunes like the Macarena is more of like a Brazilian-based dance and stuff like that. So that's not even hit the main street Latin market you know?

MR: Does a spiritual aspect of this music enter as a part of your —

WC: Oh yeah, yeah. Part of my religion also, yes.

MR: I know it was talked about a lot yesterday.

WC: Yeah. Those batá drums are ceremonial drums that we play at ceremonies, at religious ceremonies, and you have to go through a certain procedure in order to be able to touch those drums, the authentic ceremonial drums. So we go through a whole ceremony to get initiated to play those drums, like people who play those, because they have consecrated drums that are only used for these ceremonies. You know you could have the ones that we played yesterday, those are considered like conga drums, like any other, you could buy them in the store or on line, but the original ones that are done, like Cascadu said, they are tied up by rope or string or skin. They have a packet inside of the big one, like a medicine with herbs and everything like that. It's a packet. That's where the saint lives in the big one you know. And that one has to go through the ceremonies in order for them to be played by the sons of that saint, which we have to go through the ceremony and be initiated as omo ana, you know, which is the child of that saint, to touch the drum there. So you know, that's, my religion is the religion of my drum. So this is why, if you're going to go you've got to go all the way, you've got to learn my music, you know, I'm all the way, you have to learn where it came from to know where you're going. So therefore with that, and it's a whole total different thing. Now we're playing, you see it as six drums, two, four, six, each side of the batá drum. He could be playing in 6/8, him in 4/4 and me in 2. And yet meshing into one. And then the conversations those calls, you know

it takes years of study to sing, and to each Orisha has a song and it's in order, I think it's about 23, 24, between 23 and 26 Orishas, and within each song there might be four or five conversations you know. And then there's chants on top of that that sings to specific songs, so you can't sing this song with that rhythm, it doesn't go there. So you've got to know the rhythm, what it is, what is it for, which conversation are you singing it for, you can't sing this one back onto this conversation. You know so it's a lifetime thing. So that makes me understand my drum. When I go sit down and play drum I have all that power behind me you know. I have all that knowledge and right away if I just have one drum that's what is going to come out because I know every square inch of that drum, where is it coming from, what I have to play, you know, so within my whole experience of my whole lifetime so far, and I'm still learning. This is why I'm glad that I was raised in New York, like I have all those influences, and it made you — you had to learn it because the guy next to you is learning it and he's going to get the gig or whatever, you know, and if you stay back there — but this gives me another avenue also, besides playing, to teach.

MR: Right. Well I envision a part 2, 3 and 4 of an interview with you.

WC: We only scratched the surface.

MR: Yeah that's what I'm thinking. And you speak very eloquently about the music.

WC: Sure, sure. You have to, you've got to understand it that way you know. People just can't grab a horn and okay let's play. Let's play what? You know? But once you start playing and now, you know, but you've got to learn all these things first. You've got to have that theory first before playing. You know you have, like classes where you learn and you play your horn, your instrument, but what are you playing? Then you've got the theory part of it, the other part, which you've got to sit down and listen. I could put records on for you, what's he doing here, what kind of style is this here, and you've got to have that other balance so you could know first of all what are you doing, and then you grab your horn. That's another life right there you know? So it goes with every instrument you play, in any genre, classical, rock, anything you do. They have their own laws too. You know? I go play rock & roll, I paint my hair pink, you know? I color it pink, I do what you want to do, put sunglasses on, pierce my ear, my nose, hey, jump up and down but I'll play my stuff.

MR: Okay. Well I'm looking forward to the big band tonight. I think it will be just an exhilarating experience and I thank you for your time today.

WC: Thank you. Thank you very much.